

Bhattacharyas and Boses as young men take over the mantle of power from a clueless Congress in 1977 and marshalled by a man called Jyoti Basu, who was a very spirited and sprightly 63 at that time, the gradual ageing of a generation has had its impact though. The CPI(M) was a natural ally of the urbane middle class of Calcutta in the '70s. Three decades later, the party seems to have turned into an education of a people waiting to yank it out from the seat of power.

Debesh Roy, one of the top leftist intellectuals of the state, says that the "natural ally" feel has not gone for a toss. "Only Left sympathisers have got alternatives now in the fringe Marxists whose growth has been phenomenal. The official communists have been forsaken for the unofficial reds. That is the true picture. Bengal still remains clearly Leftist in its beliefs." He further adds, "The official Communist Party is ageing and is becoming an anachronism, but then a large number of communists are being made in the state every day, not necessarily in the official ranks though. That's why the age factor of the CPI(M) is now being shown up. Young people wanting to be communists are going elsewhere, particularly so in the districts."

The CPI(M) has always managed to silence its detractors with statistics, however. Just like its 65-year-old Finance Minister Asim Dasgupta who manages to project the sunny side of his Government at any presentation and who was in the early '90s described by Basu as "my US-trained minister who will show you what new ideas are". The 29-year-old state secretary of the Students' Federation of India (SFI), Kaustav Chatterjee, uses the same formula: even when facts stare you at your face indicating the opposite, show them figures to prove how wrong they are. "In 1977, the SFI had around two lakh members in the state. Today, we have 16 lakh. During the 2009 elections held in 296 colleges, we won in 183. Does this in any



Voices From Within



“It's unfair to say that we harbour only oldies. They have earned their positions and unless we have reasons to do so, there is no question of replacements.”

BIMAN BOSE
Left Front chairman



“You need a service check after the guarantee period is over. You have to allow a leadership to emerge. The CPI(M) leadership does not encourage that.”

ABDUR REJJAK MOLLAH
Minister for land and land reforms



“In order to govern, you need experience and that comes with age. Communists do not retire. We do not have personal aspirations.”

ABDUS SATTAR
Minister for minority affairs

way suggest that we do not have young members on our rolls?" His Kolkata District President Madhuja Sen Roy, 26, says, "Do not forget that in the middle of this consumerist surge, it's the Left government which has been voted back time and again because we have enabled the economics of the state to sustain that. It is we who have delivered."

Amid this talk of winning elections and influencing people, the Trinamool Congress march continues unabated. First-time MP and star of the Trinamool, Subhendu Adhikari, 39, who defeated Haldia strongman Lakshman Seth last time, says the ageing of the CPI(M) has made it easier for Trinamool leader Banerjee who is only 54. "Young people are my main support. I am not fettered by chains. My response time is immediate. I am single and I can work round the clock. People realise that I have come to stay. And I do not have to take naps in the afternoon to stay alive in the evenings."

But the CPI(M) will not own up that it is headed for the geriatric ward. Newly inducted state secretariat member Rabin Deb, 61, who has lost to Banerjee twice consecutively, says it is all in the ideals. "Mamata, too, has many leaders who are over 55 and have nothing to contribute. Issues are important, not age. Prafulla Mahanta was a rage in Assam once but he knew nothing about governance. He was a young leader. But pray, where is he now? He vanished because he had no ideals to follow."

The last word, however, comes from a CPI(M) minister himself who refused to be quoted. Apparently, one day he visited a colleague's residence and was asked to wait outside. Not the one who loves to be kept waiting, he barged inside, only to see his colleague colouring his hair. "I couldn't believe it. I had always thought that he had not greyed. I asked him why he was covering up what for me was natural." He adds, "I never had any problems with my shock of silver. But my friend felt otherwise. Cover-ups are needed, he told me." The truth is too white to miss. ■